

The CPI(M) leadership grapples to contain the growing discord within that is more of a clash of personalities than ideologies

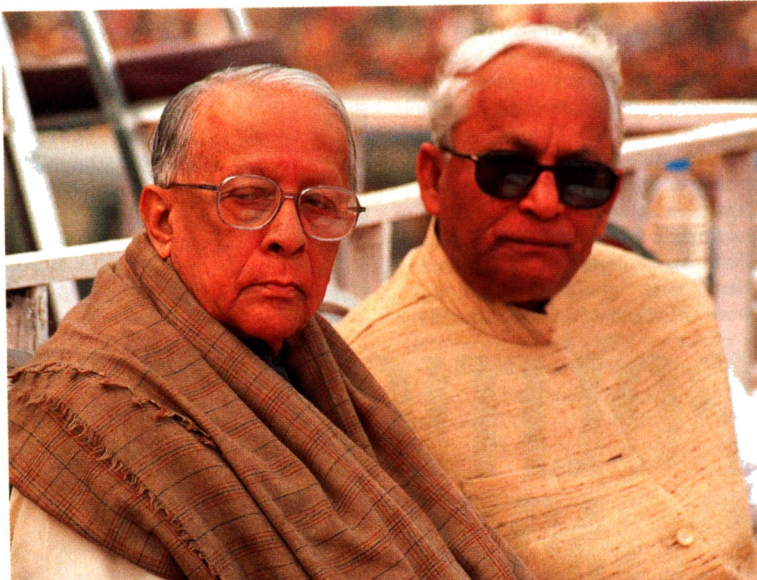


secretary Pinarayi Vijayan—from the party's highest body. The Politburo was forced to make this surgical intervention by a war of words between the two leaders. Old-timers recall that Communist legends like E.M.S. Namboothiripad and B.T. Ranadive had also been suspended from the party, but that was more because of ideological differences and not petty bourgeois personal hostilities. True, Achuthanandan, 84, belongs to the old school of dogmatic Communists, while the 62-year-old Vijayan leads a

BRIDGE TOO FAR: Basu and Bhattacharya (below); Karat flanked by Achuthanandan and Vijayan (left)

ideological position. His predecessor H.K.S. Surjeet, whose managerial skills had been tested by the party in the past decade of coalition politics in India, is now ailing. Surjeet is far removed from any decision-making exercise within the Politburo and is not in a position to guide his successor through the changes. On organisational matters, Karat's Delhi-based Politburo colleagues are of little help since most of them are busy with their own roles in Parliament, trade unions or even TV studios. Traditionally, the Politburo has been a hub of very bright strong-willed people. When he took over in 2005, Karat might have hoped

SOURMITRA GHOSH



heartland, much of Karat's time has been wasted firefighting in Kerala and Bengal

Bhattacharya seldom consults Basu on important matters of the party. Rise in incidents of crime across Nandigram and Singur following the unrest appears to suggest that the CPI(M) state command on Alimuddin Street is losing its grip over the cadres. The developments have begun to rattle the party's central leadership.

In Kerala, the fratricidal war led by two Politburo members is largely fuelled not by ideological but personal considerations. The acrimony even forced the Politburo to take the unprecedented decision of suspending both the warring leaders—Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan and state

team of moderate reformers. But more than anything else, the antagonism is fundamentally a power struggle to dominate the asset-rich party, which apart from ruling the state also runs high-tech hospitals, super markets, newspapers and magazines and even a satellite TV channel.

For general secretary Prakash Karat and Indian communism, new-age Marxism is still a troublesome concept. Staying the old course of disallowing private capital and foreign investments has also become irrelevant in today's India. Karat is unable to marry the aspirations of his new-age colleagues with that of the party's

to expand the CPI(M) base in states outside the Red bastions. But much of his attention has been diverted to firefighting in Bengal and Kerala. He is also distracted by the squabbling within the Left Front in the Capital.

While the Congress is yet to deliver on the UPA-Left's social welfare agenda, Karat knows that three years have already passed and he cannot ignore the future prospects of a non-Congress, non-BJP third alternative. The CPI(M)'s only defence is that its external support to the ruling coalition has kept BJP out of power. As if that was all that the party ever wanted to achieve.

with M.G. Radhakrishnan and Swagata Sen